UNIVERSITÉ DE GENÈVE
FACULTY OF MEDICINE
Institute of Global Health

Prof. Nicolas Ray
Director
Institute of Global Health
Campus Biotech
University of Geneva

Tel: +41 22 379 07 84
nicolas.ray@unige.ch

Swiss National Science Foundation
Ambizione programme

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Concern: Detailed confirmation of the research institution (SNSF Ambizione, Dr Erol Orel)

The Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine, University of Geneva, confirms its intention, with respect to Dr Erol Orel, to adhere to the obligations listed below should an Ambizione grant be awarded by the SNSF for the proposal entitled “HEADSTART: Forecasting health-system crises from published evidence when local outcome data are scarce”.

The research institution commits itself to host the principal investigator (PI) for the duration of the Ambizione grant and to:

- integrate the PI in the research institution and provide working space;
- support the PI in the management of their team and provide administrative assistance to the PI;
- provide research support to the PI and their team members throughout the duration of the project, in particular access rights to infrastructures, equipment, and other services as necessary for conducting the research;
- guarantee the necessary scientific independence of the PI, in particular as regards the:
  - realisation of the project under the scientific guidance of the PI;
  - selection and supervision of other team members;
  - use of the budget to achieve the scientific objectives of the project;
  - authority to publish as senior author and to invite as co-authors only those who have contributed substantially to the reported work;
- inform the PI about job openings in their field of competence.

Statement on the general interest of the research institution. The Institute’s research portfolio spans epidemiology, infectious-disease modelling and digital approaches to global health. Dr Orel’s project addresses a question of direct relevance to this portfolio: whether systematically extracted published evidence can inform operational forecasting at the onset of health crises, before local outcome data accumulate. The project builds on a prototype platform developed at the Institute, draws on the Geneva operational partnerships the Institute maintains, and creates synergies with its surveillance and evidence-synthesis activities, while its deliverables (an open extraction benchmark, an evidence-to-prior library and an evaluated forecasting framework) will benefit several of the Institute’s programmes.

Statement on the project’s autonomy. The project is autonomous from the ongoing research objectives at the Institute. It is not a work package, nor a continuation, of the GESICA programme (Interreg), the GeoAI4EI project (Horizon Europe) or the cantonal legionellosis study, to which Dr Orel contributes in defined roles: none of these programmes has as an objective the testing of automatically synthesised external evidence as formal prior information for cold-start forecasting. Dr Orel will lead the project as an independent research programme alongside the Institute’s existing research groups, under his own scientific direction, with the guarantees listed above.

The contact person acknowledges that they can only support one applicant in the current call.

Further comments. Prof. Olivia Keiser signs as contact person in her capacity as head of the research group currently employing Dr Orel; the project itself is conducted as an independent programme led by Dr Orel, hosted at Institute level.

Prof. Olivia Keiser
Contact person, Head of research group
Institute of Global Health, University of Geneva

Signature:  Date: 13 October 2026

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